



...And There Was Order!

A look at two Image Managers that bring order to your photo collection

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A digital camera has its advantages, such as low running costs, instant access to results, and so on. However, managing the images after transferring them onto your computer is a gargantuan task. With a film camera, all you had to do was click and send them to the studio for developing, and they even would give you an album to store your photos!

With digital cameras, though, your photos are now stored as files on your computer. Searching through a number of un-indexed files on your computer can be a veritable nightmare.

The problem is akin to when MP3s were the rage. You would have thousands of these files on your hard drive with none tagged properly, and searching for a particular song was tedious. Then, someone came up with a multi-feature MP3 manager that

allowed tagging, simplifying the whole process.

Similarly, today, we have managers that take impeccable care of your digital photographs. They allow you to take complete control of your digital assets, be they photographs or videos. They let you capture your photographs, tag them, fix minor problems such as red eye, apply basic effects such as blur, and share them in the form of slideshows, calendars, VCDs and much more.

To take you through some practices that you should help you take care of your digital photographs, we have chosen two of the best available managers; Adobe Photoshop Album 2.0, and Picasa 2 from Google.

As we proceed, we will look into their utility value in terms simplifying the image management process.

Taking Those Images In

Typically, images on a PC have multiple sources; they could be

those shot using your digital camera, a scanned photograph, photos taken by your mobile phone or even wallpapers downloaded from the Internet. So, an image manager should have the option of capturing images from all possible sources. The process of acquiring images is often termed 'importing'.

As you will see, Photoshop Album 2.0 has a neat, simple interface for importing photographs. It has options for importing from cameras, scanners, mobile phones and folders on your hard disk.

Picasa 2, too, has a similar, simple-to-use interface, but lacks the structured segregation offered by the Adobe product.

Once the photographs are imported from the respective devices, they are stored on your hard drive. In Windows XP, 'My Pictures' is the default folder for storing images. However, as far as possible, avoid storing your photos in this folder. There are